

Early detection of cancer: Ideas for a debate

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Abstract

Even if the overall number of cancer is increasing, the mortality has started to decrease in the Western World. The role of early detection in this decrease is a matter of debate. To assess its impact on mortality it is important to distinguish between diagnosis of cancer in symptomatic patients, and early detection in asymptomatic individuals who may self-refer or who may be offered ad hoc or systematic screening. The policies for early detection and screening vary greatly between European countries, despite many similarities in their cancer burden, and this partly reflects the uncertainties surrounding asymptomatic testing for cancer.

A Task Force of European expert, held in Azzate (VA), Italy, established to address these issues, acknowledged the need for more research in the field of individual risk assessment since general statistics are more and more perceived as inadequate to design personal early detection plans. The group also recognised that combinations of early detection and screening will enforce the effectiveness of new treatments in curbing mortality curves, although policies will vary with different cancers.

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